

Group Study Unlocked
 Tips on teaching and preparing a Shiur
 Kinus Hashluchos 5773

1. LIMUD TORAH-YOUR GREATEST MOST EFFECTIVE PEULAH

- The best way to impact people is through learning. Knowledge is Empowering! Gedolah Limud shemaivee liday maaseh-if they don't learn, they don't know and can't grow.

Strides are taken in Yiddishkeit only through learning-women have gone to the Mikvah, Kashered their homes, added in Shabbos observance etc...only because of the class. Women's Circle programs get the women through the door, but by teaching classes you are actually impacting their lives in a real way-not only their lives but the lives of their children and families as well.

- Forging Friendships-You and the women of your weekly Shiur become a close family, and friendships are formed between the women themselves.
- You get to exercise your brain!! By teaching you get the chance to learn yourself and challenge your brain :)
- Feel intimidated, unqualified or think you don't know enough to teach? If you know an Aleph, teach an Aleph. Everyone has something to give over.
- No Deposit, No Return. As with all of Shlichus, the more we give the more we get, but the satisfaction we get from teaching real Torah and giving meaning to these precious Yidden cannot be compared.

2. GETTING STARTED:

- a) Choose the best day and time: Know what works best for you and your community. Are your kids younger so you have the night to yourself? Are the women you are targeting working women who prefer the evenings, or moms who can come during the day? You may also want to base your decision on women who are interested already-choose what works best for their schedule.
- b) Choose a topic: When choosing a topic to teach, always choose something that excites you, and that you can realistically prepare and teach. (Will you have the time to research Tanya or Talmudic stories etc...?) .

Some ideas for topics:

1) **Tefillah:** I taught this over the course of 3-4 months.

- Each woman ordered the blue Kehos Siddur so that we could all be on the “same page”.
- Buy all sorts and sizes of Post it Notes-let women mark and tab their Siddurim in whatever way they feel is best (i.e Birchas Hashachar one color, Psukai Dizimra in another color...)
- At the end of the course, I gave each woman a Tefillah Trax CD with the laminated Tefillah guide

2) **Parshah:** Always a classic. Can be taught yearly with a focus on different aspects of the Parshah

- Look through the Parshah to see if any Mitzvah/idea appeals to you. Be creative with your ideas and topics!
- Give out a list of all the Parshios for the ladies to keep in the beginning of their binder. (See sample). This way they can follow along and see which Parsha you are up to that week.
- Choose a Mitzvah to focus on i.e Parshas Chayai Sara=Mikvah, Mishpotim=Kashrus, Behar=Shmittah etc..., or teach a Sichah of the Rebbe
- There are lots of resources for Parshah material, some of my favorite are:

*Nechama Greisman's Through The Eyes of a Woman

*Torah Studies (Jonathan Sacks)

*The Inside Story

*Chassidic Dimension

3) **Upcoming Yomim Tovim:** Should be taught/reviewed yearly, even though you may have taught it before

- Bring holiday related visual aids (Lulav, Esrog, Menorah...)
- Serve appropriate holiday foods i.e. Purim: Hamantashen, Chanukah: donuts, Tu Bshvat: Shivas Haminim....
- I make a Farbrengen for Chassidishe Yomim Tovim too, like YT Kislev and Yud Shvat. I talk about the meaning of the day, we say a L'Chaim, we share thoughts...it's a nice break from the weekly class, and the women really enjoy it.

4) **Tanya:** More of a challenge to prepare and teach, but well worth it

- Sources with which to prepare:
Opening the Tanya- Adin Steinsaltz
Themes in Tanya -Yekutiel Green
Chabad.org-Audio Tanya classes by Manis Freidman, Rabbi Krasnianski etc...
A Tale of Two Souls-Rabbi Yossi Jacobson
- Visual aids Props if possible: Klipa, Levushim etc... (see above)

5) **Tehillim:** This can be a one-time class, or I have taught it as a mini series. Very important for the women to know about the concept and power of Tehillim.

- Encourage women to buy a pocket size Tehillim-guide them as to where to purchase one. You'd be surprised at how many will do so, and will actually begin to say Tehillim (if they cannot read Hebrew, it is completely fine for them to read it in the English). It is much less overwhelming and intimidating than Davening.
- Begin a Tehillim Women's community group. We began this over 10 years ago and people from all over the community will call us to add a name to the Cholim list (a woman is in charge of keeping a Cholim list which she emails out to the women in the group). We call our group the "Women's Tehillim of Unity and Healing"

6) Mikvah:

- Recommend the book "Total Immersion" (Rivkah Slonim)
- Know your crowd-Don't overwhelm them
- MAD (Mikvah Awareness Day) about Mikvah day for men and women:

7) Moshiach: A must to teach. The women in my class asked me over the course of several years to teach about Moshiach, as we made reference to it many times throughout the classes. I was very hesitant to teach this topic, but it was so well received and the response was terrific bh.

- Moshiach by Immanuel Schochet is a great book to use

8) Misc: The Mystery of the Aleph Bais, Pirkai Avos, Creating Sacred Space, topics suggested by women in your class, or any topic-be creative!! (personally I like to choose topics that have practical relevance to their lives)

C) Recruiting Women/Advertising: Create a distribution list (if using outlook) or a group list for your women's class attendees, and send out weekly email reminders a few days in advance. Follow up-call or email women who were absent to say you missed them. A little care goes a long way. Have a woman host the class in her home, so she invites her friends.

I send out the following email reminder on Sundays:

Women's Parsha class email reminder:

An Island of Serenity, A Lighthouse in Time!

Join the Women's Weekly Roundtable, an intriguing and personal weekly Torah discussion of the practical and the mystical and its contemporary relevance. Fresh hot coffee and delicious baked goods always served! Looking forward to studying with all of you, Sara

Or: Join us as we explore this week's Torah Portion, and discuss its lessons and relevance to our daily lives. Fresh hot coffee and delicious baked goods always served! Looking forward to studying with all of you, Sara

3. PREPARING A GOOD SHIUR:

Some points to keep in mind before you begin:

The art of preparing and teaching a good Shiur does not happen overnight. It's a Chush that develops with time and practice.

In addition, once you begin teaching you are creating a large database in your brain of stories, information and lessons so that when you are teaching about a certain subject, you can draw on your previous knowledge and connect it to what you are teaching. This makes preparation easier over time.

It's ok if you don't know all the answers, they will respect you regardless and you can always look up the answer (GALOR) and tell them the following week.

1. Set aside time to prepare-try to keep it consistent and keep that time free of other activities. For me this is the biggest challenge-finding the time to prepare properly-it takes hrs to prepare a good class.
2. Everyone has a unique teaching style-important to identify your style. I prefer discussion over just learning, you may prefer just learning no discussions.
3. Best Kept secret: Chabad.org and the internet. You can search and (usually) find any story you are looking for, and lots of info on any given topic.
4. Collect all your info and research you find in one document (cut and paste). Once you have gathered all the material, sort through it, organize and outline your lesson (the hard part :). Footnotes-look them up in the source (Talmud-an English set is a must have) and use quote. Know what you are teaching well- i.e. if you are teaching a story of the Parsha, read the Midrash Says so you will be well prepared for potential questions on the subject matter.
5. Try to include at least one story per class. Stories bring the lesson to life and will be remembered.
6. Always give a handout-this allows them to review what they've learned and share the knowledge with their families and friends. Handouts also give an outline and structure not just for the participants but also for yourself-they help you keep focused as you teach the class
7. Always end your class with a quick review/summary of what you have just covered.
8. Say a Kapitul Tehillim before you start, asking Hashem to put the right words in your mouth.

4. GENERAL TIPS:

- Food & Coffee add an important touch (invest in a Keurig machine-very elegant) – these are small things that make a big difference!
- Charge a minimal fee so women take it seriously \$75/year
- Have a monthly Lunch N Learn to add some flair-I do this the Tuesday closest to Rosh Chodesh. The class is hosted in one of the women's homes, and she sponsors a store bought lunch for everyone. It's a nice change.
- Offer free babysitting for Moms with kids
- Give binders with clear pocket in front for binder cover-invest in a big hole puncher

- Use as many visual aids as you can. When teaching about a certain upcoming Holiday, bring in associated food i.e. dried fruits and Shivas Haminim for Tu B'Shvat, donuts and latkas for Chanukah... When teaching Tanya, use visual aids to introduce concepts, if applicable. Some examples: Klipah=show fruits and or veggies with peel. 3 Levushim: bring in different clothing and demonstrate the concept by putting clothing on and then off... ZOOM- Excellent book to buy, can be used to teach Hashgacha Protis or Kabbalah (or any optical illusion activity) etc...
- Dry erase board-Use this to help reinforce concepts and to draw/illustrate difficult concepts you are teaching. I found this extremely helpful when teaching Perek Bais of Tanya-I drew the lessons on the board each week to show Seder Hishtalshelus, different levels of Neshama....
- The Maaleh of teaching the same class twice-you get to perfect it :). Always add/edit the lesson after you have taught it so you have an even better class for the next time. (Must do within a day of teaching the class, otherwise you'll forget (at least I do :))
- Recycle-I'm a big fan of recycling classes, no one will remember all the details and they will see it from a different perspective at this point in their lives. Also keep in mind that Yiddishkeit is foreign to them so they do need to hear things once, twice and even three times for the knowledge to seep in. (I try to add in one or two different ideas and change the font :)

Feel free to email me for any prepared Shiurim-if I have it I am happy to share it.

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